PRELUDE XXIV

THIS Prelude exists in two notations: in common time, as here, and in *Alla-breve*. Kroll, in *Edition Peters*, decided for the present notation, but in the *Bach-Gesellschaft* edition came to the conclusion that Bach wrote it in *alla-breve* for convenience. Bischoff, taking this for granted, infers from it, and from no other fact whatever, that the MSS. described by him as Altnikol II. is later than Altnikol I., because it gives the *Alla-breve* version (Altnikol II. was unknown to Kroll). On the other hand, Prout, a very accurate and shrewd observer, concludes that Altnikol I. represents Bach's final conclusion in this as in other matters. It is quite certain that there was a danger of taking the *Alla-breve tempo* too slow, for Bach had to put the direction *Allegro* into the *Alla-breve* copies; a fact which also shows that it is sometimes possible to march a brisk four (though unwise to beat more than two) to Bach's *Alla-breve* movements; thus removing any grounds for uneasiness as to a broad *tempo* for the E♭ and B major Fugues in this Book.

Undoubtedly it is impossible to miss the right *tempo* here with the common-time notation; the high-spirited swing of the tunes at once carries the player away from the reflective mood of the A minor Prelude of this Book, while the ornamental aspect of the notation warns the player betimes against the disasters that await the rash sight-reader of the D♯ minor Prelude. But here there is little need to hold back, since the present demisemiquaver figures are mostly energetic turns very different from the delicate figures of that subtle composition. On the other hand, the second theme, with its swing of direct and inverted figures (bars 5-6) and its broad rising sequence (bars 7-8), must on no account lack grace: and the authentic *staccato* dashes in bar 11 must be understood as breathings, not as hits. They throw the weight of the phrase back to its entry (compare Prelude XVII., bars 5-6). Bach is never perky. Quavers in *arppeggio* may be slightly detached, but always with singing tone. A fine deep contralto colour should be aimed at throughout; think of the *chalumeau* register of a solo clarinet (in chamber music, not in the orchestra, where it fails to dominate), or the warmest possible viola playing. It is a relief to be allowed to prefer the noble Altnikol reading of bar 29 to the more obvious autograph version, which, however, it would be wrong to withhold. It is here, of course, transcribed into the present notation. The autograph reading in bar 4 is preferable; it differs from Altnikol's (perhaps later) text as looking forward to the next bar, while his reading looks back to the immediately preceding figure. But Altnikol's reading is not upheld in bar 32. The discrepancy does not settle the question, for it may be covered by harmonic exigencies. The turn ∼ should differ from those written out as semiquavers, by being compressed so as to throw stress on the main note.
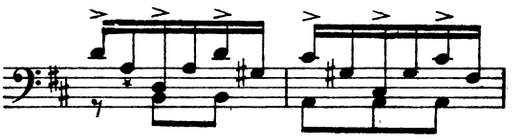
FUGUE XXIV

THIS Fugue, perhaps the most sonorous three-part piece ever written for any less instrument than the organ, is in the same vigorous mood as its Prelude. There is little temptation to force the tone, the position of every note being remarkably favourable to the modern pianoforte; but there is some danger of monotony for the listener while the pianist is enjoying his own easy exercise of strength. Nor is there much opportunity for contrast, since the Episodes are short, arising (as in bars 12-15) imperceptibly from the end of the Subject; while the most important Episode is an urgent rising sequence demanding a *crescendo*, and actually recurring together with an earlier Episode as the climax and Coda of the Fugue. Some reserve of tone, then, is necessary at the outset; though you have but to sing the Subject to realise that the person who would play

Donald Francis Tovey: The Well-Tempered Clavier, Book II
Associated Board, 1924. Printed pp. 174-175.
BWV 893. Complete original pages; adjoining commentary is retained.
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it either *legato* or in an elegant hen-like *staccato*, would consider the Elgin Marbles either pretty or quaint. The best way to manage the tone is to let the beginning of each Episode drop rather suddenly into a *piano* which changes to a *crescendo* on approaching the next entry. This always makes good sense, and, indeed, brings out the form very naturally and clearly. In two places it is impossible to withhold from the student the different readings of the autograph and the Altnikol MSS. In bar 16 the Altnikol reading is for several reasons the best; but in bar 21 the autograph reading facilitates a fresh start for the Episode, justifying the convenient drop to a *piano* before making a *crescendo* to the cardinally important entry in bar 26.

In the Exposition the counterpoint to the Subject is virtually a regular Countersubject, but makes a point of imitating the Subject in the second bar (bar 8); with far-reaching cumulative results at later stages of the Fugue. Soon after the Exposition the next entry launches the Fugue into a wider current. The treble imitates the second bar, as did the Countersubject; but the bass enters (bar 29) with a new theme, which from henceforward invariably accompanies the Subject, thus acquiring from its delayed appearance and its firm establishment the importance of a Second Subject. The player must make its entry very conspicuous, nor need he be worried by the fact that no human ingenuity will prevent the combination from sounding like this:



It is a mistake to try any eccentricities of touch in order to clear up an ambiguity which is, after all, one of the points of the passage. The listener knows the First Subject by this time, and hears that some equally vigorous semiquaver movement is coiling around it in a thick mass of harmony; and if the player marks the first A (*) as an entry and takes his right thumb out of the keys, his duty to the part-writing is duly performed and he can enjoy the freedom of the key-board. In the next entry the Subjects are an octave apart, and nothing could be clearer; we can then take the Second Subject as a *legatissimo*, like that of a viola or violoncello playing across two strings. In fact, each of the six entries of the pair has a different colour, according to the particular way in which they cross.

Episode 5 had better start with a downright *fp* at bar 50 (keep it *legatissimo*, and do not phrase off the sequences); so as to make a five-bar *crescendo* that can be remembered by the listener when the passage recurs. Episode 6 (bars 60-70) is long enough to relax the tone into a real *piano* from which the *crescendo* can begin to revive in the bass of bar 67. Then, prepared by formal emphasis on the dominant, comes the significant false entry in bar 70, diverted by the bass into the subdominant, where the real entry occurs. Bars 69-73 thus constitute an incident of dramatic dialogue after which the tension may again be relaxed until the final entry (bar 81), from which point there is a fine opportunity for a steady *crescendo* graded carefully from the beginning of the Subject, through the growing urgency of the last Episode, which combines Episodes 3 and 5, until the last four bars, where Bach ends with one of his favourite devices, the imitation of the main figure in three octaves (here ornamented in the top part).

The excellent *appoggiaturas* given by good authorities in bars 46 and 100 are best taken at the lengths here indicated; but no objection can be maintained against making a semiquaver of that in bar 46 and a quaver of that in bar 100.